

AMAZON'S INDIA A-TEAM

The e-commerce giant, through its various divisions, is focussed on a local approach



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“From where India’s per capita income is today placed (\$2,400), it can take off [and] along with that, consumption as well. That is the magic about India,” Thota says.

Harish Iyer, EVP (Media & Investments) at Interactive Avenues, India’s largest digital agency, says that the trust that Amazon has built as a reliable e-commerce platform is a significant advantage for D2C brands. “Leveraging Amazon’s reputation plus its customer base and robust algorithms can catapult these brands to new heights of visibility and consumer trust. The ‘fulfilment’ backend helps simplify logistics for these brands, allowing them more time to enhance product quality and marketing strategies,” Iyer says.

A key feature of Amazon’s strategy is its wide range: customers should be able to shop, make payments, buy flight tickets and

gold—get pretty much everything. Then there is Amazon Pay, which Amazon India launched in February 2019 to capitalise on the market opportunity offered by UPI. Amazon Pay users do not have to enter their bank or debit card details.

Mahendra Nerurkar, Vice President for India & Emerging Markets Payments at Amazon Pay, explains why being open to newer payment processing methods in a market like India is important. “Limited credit card penetration showed how large cash was, and with UPI, there is more engagement on Amazon today. It is a universal phenomenon in Singapore, Australia and Mexico and has greatly simplified user experience.”

A big hitch in credit cards was the redemption of points. Amazon’s co-branded card with ICICI Bank addresses that and makes it easy for the customer.

A pertinent question is when will Amazon start to become profitable. Tiwary speaks of a clear road map. “We are a large company, and this is a commercial enterprise. We are very happy with the progress and the trajectory, with the primary objective continuing to be customer experience,” he explains.

Amazon has been here for over a decade, and Indianisation is visible. With its tech expertise and scale, there is a good chance that growth will continue. But with Amazon losing the Future Retail piece, Tiwary will need all the other growth engines to fire. It helps that Amazon has a long-term approach and vision for India. That patience will make success possible in the vastly complicated Indian terrain. That is what Amazon is banking on. **BT**

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